

Checking Your Pet's Vitals at Home

Knowing how to check your pet's vital signs helps you **communicate with your veterinary team** and helps us figure out the cause of "**seizure-like**" **episodes** (for example, fainting from a heart problem).

Vital sign	Normal (dog, at rest)	Concerning
Heart rate	60–100 bpm (up to 120–140 when excited)	Below 50, above 160, or irregular
Breathing rate	10–30 breaths/min	Labored, or above 40 at rest
Temperature	100–102.5 °F	Below 99 or above 103 °F
Gum color	Pale pink, moist	Pale/white, bright red, blue/purple, yellow

Small dogs and cats normally have faster heart rates (cats ~140–220 bpm).

Heart rate

Feel the **femoral pulse** on the inside of the back leg, between the groin and the knee. Count beats for **15 seconds × 4** = beats per minute. Note whether the rhythm is **regular or irregular**.

Breathing rate

Watch the chest rise and fall while your pet is resting or asleep. Count for **30 seconds × 2** = breaths per minute.

Panting during activity is normal and is not the same as labored breathing.

Body temperature

- **Rectal (most accurate):** use a digital thermometer with a disposable cover and lubricant. Gently insert into the rectum and wait for the reading. Stop if your pet becomes stressed or it is unsafe for you or your pet.
- **Armpit (less accurate):** with your pet sitting or standing, place the tip deep in the armpit and hold the leg down against the body until the reading is complete.

Gum color

Gently lift the lip and look at the gums:

- **Pale or white** — shock, anemia
- **Bright red** — overheating, toxins
- **Blue or purple** — lack of oxygen, low body temperature, heart problems
- **Yellow** — liver disease, red blood cell destruction

Take your pet to an emergency room right away for any life-threatening situation — trouble breathing, collapse, blue or white gums, or a seizure longer than 5 minutes.